PRELUDE XVII

THE formal opening, with its homophonic chords, has not proceeded beyond two bars before it becomes a dialogue between the right hand and the left. After eight bars it settles into a broad two-part design, combining sequences of its main figure with a new theme in double counterpoint, establishing the key of the dominant and closing therein at bar 18. Then the opening formal style is resumed, soon to develop into fresh double counterpoint, and leading to the subdominant where, in bar 26, the whole passage from bar 9-18 is inverted in double counterpoint (the last three bars freely) so as to return firmly to the tonic. From bar 35 to the end, a Coda gathers up the remaining threads and makes a spirited climax to this openly symmetrical design.

The *tempo* is a cheerful *Allegretto*. The chords should be firm, fresh, and not too short; the quavers a not too dry *staccato;* and the semiquavers a good vocal *legato coloratura*. In bars 17 and 34 ∾ stands for an ordinary cadential shake; elsewhere it is quite short.

FUGUE XVII

THE *tempo* of this Fugue is best determined by trying the soprano by itself from the second quarter of bar 27 to the entry of the Subject in bar 30. When you have conceived the ambition of getting this broad soprano sequence to sound as if sung in one breath throughout its extent of twelve crotchets, then you will see that this Fugue loses breadth if it is played too slow. It is these sustained sequences that are its important events—not the entries of its one-bar Subject, distinct though these must always be. There is no room for anything but the broadest *legato* in the touch, unless a certain bell-like uniform detachment in the quavers be preferred.

The Subject requires a delicate but clear accent on its third quaver, to show the third beat of the bar. The Countersubject (consisting, when complete, of a group of eight semiquavers answered by its inversion) gives rise (with the aid of its extension in bar 3, which originates the above-mentioned broad soprano sequence) to most of the Episodes. Of these, the most important is that in bars 11-12, which is in triple counterpoint in the twelfth and octave. Its inversion with the semiquaver figure in the twelfth is seen in bars 14-15, the resulting harmony being quite new. (Note the full tone implied for Bach's instruments by the low bass.) Another inversion (all in the octave) is given in bars 19-20. It is followed by allusions to the Subject, which should be less emphatic than real entries, especially as immediately afterwards the Subject appears twice (bars 23-24) with its principal interval heightened—a point of rhetorical importance. Bars 27-30, as already mentioned, initiate a climax, which steadily increases to the end, culminating in Bach's ultimate resource—the use of short chords (always in real parts) punctuated by rests. Note also that in bar 27 the bass enters after a long rest, and must not sound like a mere continuation of the tenor which has run down to meet it.

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